

Pioneers, warriors, dreamers and adventurers, they stretched the limits of the freedom they were born into

India performs at its best, in words or on the screen, the world is transfixed—and such moments are not rare. We are not some remote oriental exotica any longer. We are an interesting bunch of people, capable of a few miracles.

We are here because our national back story is populated by people who are more interesting. Canonised by history, exaggerated by memory, they are not just the protagonists of a great yesterday. They are the ones who set the stage for those who came after them to play out their romance. Pioneers, warriors, revolutionaries, innovators, dreamers, adventurers and creators, they stretched the limits of the freedom they were born into. They challenged the dead certainties of their times with the power of ideas, conviction—and faith in themselves. They shattered the idyll of consensus and pitted their own will against the scepticism of the majority. Some of them played god as they gave themselves to the temptations of the alternative. Some of them pointed their accusatory fingers toward the self-styled gods of the era. And all of them, in varying degrees of originality and audacity, acknowledged the indispensability of questions—and the uses of dissent.

They are the men and women who have made India a place of perpetual astonishment, a country whose stability is built on a million imperfections. Most of them are the people we read about in textbooks. They are the permanent residents of the mythology we make out of hero-worship. They are known by a simple word: great. It is an adjective overused in history books and by popular media. It is not necessarily synonymous with fame; it is given to a chosen few in gratitude, by a people indebted. It evokes awe and admiration, and owes its origin to achievement. The INDIA TODAY list of the 60 Greatest Indians does more than showcase the familiar. Nevertheless, they are all there, certainly, from

those who were in the vanguard of the freedom struggle to those who managed the freedom. From those who stood up to the Empire to those who built empires of their own—of the mind and the money. From those who have made politics and morality seamlessly compatible to those who have redeemed India in their imagination. This list captures the evolution of the Indian story in portraits of individual exceptionalism. It is the

The Poll

The poll began on March 14 and ran for three weeks through the INDIA TODAY website and SMS. A total of 18,928 votes came in, with Bhagat Singh leading with 6,982 votes, Subhas Chandra Bose coming second with 5,193 votes and Mahatma Gandhi trailing at 2,457 votes. Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, who forever stepped aside for Jawaharlal Nehru, has been redeemed in posterity, at fourth position with 8 per cent of the votes, compared to just 2 per cent for Nehru. Another steely nationalist, Indira Gandhi, is sixth, with 3 per cent of the votes.

history of a nation personified, and a celebration of the spirit that breaches borders.

It is, most tellingly, a reflection of the changing perception of those who are remembering. Greatness, it seems, is not static, or absolute. It continues to be reappraised in the mind of the indebted. The one who tops the INDIA TODAY list is not the most obvious, the Mahatma, but the Martyr. In our poll, the action hero who struggled to give a revolutionary rejoinder to the British Empire pushes the savant of passive resistance to the third position. And next to Bhagat Singh is another rebel and adventurer who too didn't take the Gandhian road to national liberation:

Subhas Chandra Bose. The top 10 subvert many assumptions about greatness and how it is perceived by a generation that is not entirely conditioned by the one-dimensional wisdom of the classroom. The pioneer, the poet and the scientist coexist with leaders who were not conformists; and surprisingly, Nehru—nation-builder, moderniser, secularist, socialist—is at the ninth position, between Homi Bhabha and Jayaprakash Narayan. With Sardar Patel at the fourth and Indira Gandhi at the sixth positions, the list is a celebration of nationalists with iron in their soul—or in their fist.

Is it that, as India, which at any rate is hardly Gandhian or Nehruvian in its political expression, strives for global power status, someone out there, someone disillusioned with the conformism of a smug state, is missing the romance of the revolutionary leap—and the martyr's war cry, *Inquilab Zindabad*? Is it that the mystique of the deviant, the transcontinental adventurism of the rebellious, is more alluring than the intimate humanism of the fakir? Is it that a steely nationalist like Patel and a strong, overpowering helmswoman like Mrs G are missing in an India of wishy-washy pretenders to the throne? Is it that India is nostalgic about the moral power of a JP at a time when the so-called socialists, products of his 'total revolution', are an embarrassment to his memory? The hierarchy of greatness on the list reveals the mind of India. It brings out the way in which a nation comes to terms with its past and how it argues with the present. Its iconography essays a people's aspiration, their nostalgia, their disillusion, their hope, their joy—and the gaping absences in the bestselling story of India Rising.

Greatness, in the end, is a creation of the beholder. It is not the suspension of judgement that ensures the durability of the greatest. As in the following pages, the march of the 60 greatest is led by the questioning mind of an India inspired.